

prayed about what kind of a car we should buy. It didn't seem logical to spend the money to repair the old wagon when it had so many miles on it.

We didn't really have enough money to buy a new car, but with my teaching schedule and frequent trips to the airport, I knew that we needed a dependable vehicle. During the next few weeks I discovered how many times you pull into a parking space that you have to back out of.

While we were praying about what to do, someone actually gave a car to the ministry. But it had a lot of miles on it too, so I figured I might as well keep the one I had and give the donated car to a really needy family. One of my children suggested that I give away the car with no reverse, but I vetoed that idea.

I drove my "no-reverse" car for several more months because the Lord directed us to use the money we had saved for another purpose. Then, in December, someone I had counseled several years earlier dropped by to ask if we had any particular need for a car.

"Why do you ask?" I said.

"Because I am convinced that the Lord wants me to give you one," he replied as he handed me the keys to a new Oldsmobile, which I drove for the next six years.

THE UNSCHEDULED

Do you know how to schedule a financial disaster? It's simple: just fail to plan for predictable expenses that haven't come due yet. A common example of this is failing to plan for routine automobile maintenance. I don't know about your cars, but mine have a regular cycle of problems. About every 25,000 to 30,000 miles they need tires, brakes, belts, spark plugs, and so on. Once I recognize that, the smart thing to do is to anticipate those expenses and budget for them.

Failure to plan this way is a major reason many people end up in debt. When the expenses occur, they must be paid, so the only alternative available is often a credit card.